

HOUSING AND URBAN POVERTY ALLEVIATION

Kumari Selja 47



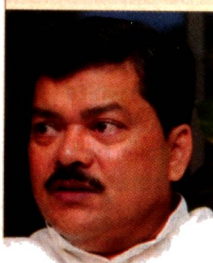
A Sonia favourite, she would rather be Haryana chief minister. The youthful minister is more of a familiar face in Delhi's Khan Market and the conference circuit than urban slums.

***THE FUNDS** Rs 677 crore in 2008-09 to Rs 858 crore in 2009-10.

THE AGENDA To execute the prime minister's dream of a slum-free India in five years. Theoretically, she has done her homework. But most of her achievements are in the form of draft notes and conferences.

SOCIAL JUSTICE AND EMPOWERMENT

Mukul Wasnik 50



A debonair Dalit poster boy and a former Youth Congress chief, he is one of the go-getters inherited from Rajiv's Congress. A Congress general secretary, he is handling the elections in Jharkhand.

***THE FUNDS** Rs 2,475 crore in 2008-09 to Rs 2,585 crore now.

THE AGENDA Wants to bring in a more comprehensive bill for the disabled and speed up cases filed under atrocities against scs and sts. Has finalised a concept paper for the Prime Minister's Adarsh Gram Yojana to develop villages with over 50 per cent Dalits.

TRIBAL AFFAIRS

Kantilal Bhuria 59



A tribal, he had been a lacklustre mos in the UPA's first stint. He wants to do a lot but lacks the requisite know-how to work the system. Is a part of the Cabinet's social engineering.

***THE FUNDS** Rs 1,984 crore in 2008-09 (including state plans) to Rs 3,220 crore this year.

THE AGENDA In a hurry to implement the Forest Rights Act that gives land rights to tribals even though most tribals are complaining about being left out. Like the minister before him, he too is working on a national tribal policy.

P. Chidambaram at the home ministry ; or between a P.R. Kyndiah and Mani Shankar Aiyar at panchayati raj.

Incidentally, all the ministers in charge of seven key social sector ministries are first-time cabinet ministers though some have previous experience as ministers of state. It is a mixed bunch. There is Mukul Wasnik, the Dalit posterboy of the UPA; the erudite C.P. Joshi; the earnest Mallikarjun Kharge and B.K. Handique; the complacent Kumari Selja, a Sonia favourite, a rather lost Kantilal Bhuria, and Krishna Tirath. All of them have been given roadmaps by the Prime Minister's Office (PMO). Yet, very little seems to have taken off the ground. Most have not moved any bill as yet—and the few that have have not seen them passed.

The academic Joshi had the reputation of a performer in his earlier stint as state minister for rural development and education in Rajasthan. But he has not been able to do much in his new job even though he is handling the Congress party's trophy scheme, the NREGA. For him, the main hurdle seems to be the system. "The NREGA is supposed to be implemented by the states. One problem is that we are unable to give regular payments. The village post offices are ill-equipped to disburse the money. Either we go in for transparency or we disburse the funds ourselves," he says. According to Planning Commission sources, in 2007-08, the states could utilise 82 per cent of the funds while in 2008-09, the funds available went up by 19 per cent but utilisation went down to 72 per cent.

Yet the NREGA is still being touted as a success story. It has Rahul Gandhi's patronage and the Finance Ministry's largesse. Within Raisina Hill the scheme is referred to as the UPA's favourite slush fund. This year's budget has been increased to Rs 39,100 crore despite under-utilisation of funds. Clearly, Joshi has a lot of loopholes to plug. Getting Sonia and Rahul on the dais at his ministry functions may get the appropriate photo-ops but it is clearly not the solution. Spending is not the solution, governance is.

According to Mani Shankar Aiyar, a former minister for the North-east and the panchayati raj, the answer lies in decentralisation. "None of the Central ministers want to surrender control to local bodies," points out Aiyar, adding that "the politics of our poverty is reflected in the poverty of our politics". Joshi agrees that schemes like the NREGA can be used to empower local bodies but is yet to implement his thoughts.

The need of the hour is for some out-of-the-box thinking. Not for repackaging the same jargon into new labels. Take Women and Child Development Minister Krishna Tirath's nascent plans for the proposed National Mission for Empowerment of Women and compare these to the draft of National Policy for the Empowerment of Women (2001). Ten years later, Tirath is still unfolding plans to strengthen anti-dowry laws and curb domestic violence. All very déjà vu except perhaps her proposal to create resource centres that will work as a single window delivery system to converge all